

402MAN

# Communication Models & Miscommunication



Coventry University

**Top 15 UK university  
5 years running**

Guardian University Guide 2016-2020

Coventry University

**Gold for outstanding  
teaching and learning**

Teaching Excellence  
Framework (TEF) 2017

Coventry University

**97% employed  
or in further study**

DLHE survey, UG UK, 2016/17  
(published 2018)

## Recap on previous learning:

The Oxford English Dictionary defines communication as "the imparting, conveying, or exchange of ideas, knowledge and information'. This can apply to words or body language.

Define Linear communication- what does this mean to you?

What are the benefits and challenges that come with Linear Communication Models?



## Session Intent:

- Explore both Lasswell's and Berlo's models of communication and consider how to apply these models in communication
- Consider how we can communicate effectively and avoid errors or miscommunication

# Relevance?

This session links to the following Learning Outcome:

**LO1-** Demonstrate a knowledge of the core principles, theories and differing methods of communication and collaboration within a range of organisational contexts.



# Clear Communication Model

As mentioned in previous sessions, clear communication models are valuable and help aid with clarity and getting the message across.

Consider why and how Shannon-Weaver and Aristotles Communication Models are considered clear communication models.

Shannon-Weaver Model  
– Focuses on reducing noise and ensuring the message reaches the receiver.

Aristotle's Model – Uses ethos (credibility), pathos (emotion), and logos (logic) to persuade effectively.

# Getting the correct message across is crucial

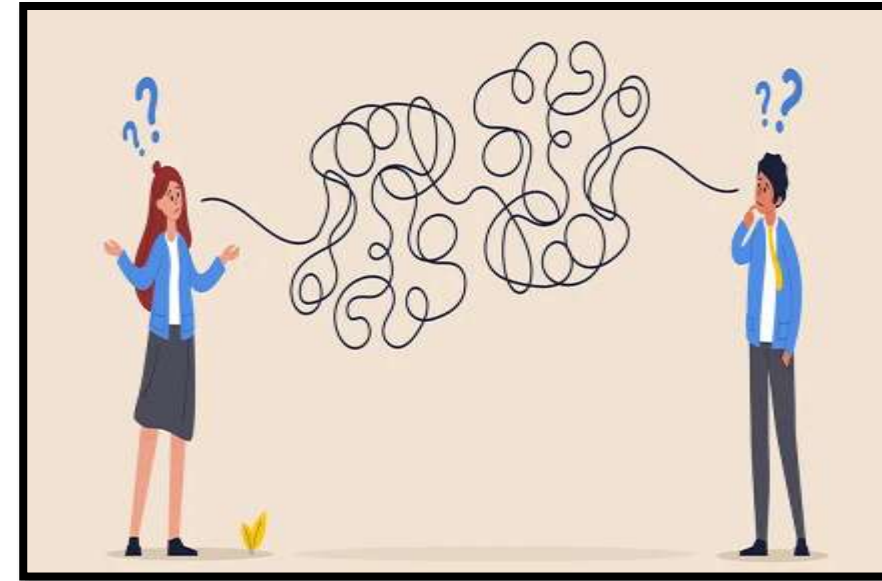
- Effective communication is the foundation of success in both leadership and business but is equally important in teamwork.
- Effective communication plays an increasingly vital role in both personal and professional settings. Understanding the complexities of the communication process can be challenging.
- Using communication models helps structure messages, reduce misunderstandings, and ensure the intended message is received correctly.



Fujishin, Randy (2009)

# Miscommunication Errors

- Miscommunication occurs when there is a breakdown or distortion in the communication process, leading to misunderstandings, confusion, or even business failures.
- It is an instance where either the speaker is unable to provide the proper and adequate information to the audience or the listeners misperceive or cannot recognise the message from the speaker.
- The cases of miscommunication vary depending on the situation and persons included in it, but often result in confusion and frustration.
- As defined by Oxford Languages (2024) miscommunication is “failure to communicate adequately”.



How can we prevent  
miscommunication?

# How Does Clear Communication Drive Success in Business & Leadership?

- **Clear communication avoids confusion** – Misinterpretation can lead to costly mistakes.
- **Enhances collaboration** – Teams work better when information flows smoothly.
- **Builds trust and credibility** – Leaders and managers gain respect through transparent and effective messaging.
- **Boosts productivity** – Employees perform better when instructions are clear.
- **Improves customer relationships** – Brands that communicate well build loyalty.



# Communicating a Message Through the Appropriate Channel

- Choosing the right communication model is crucial for ensuring your message is clear, effective, and reaches the intended audience in the correct manner.
- The choice depends on factors including the level of urgency, audience & size, complexity of the message, and feedback mechanisms.
- When communicating, it's important to factor in any 'noise' that can occur and distract audience members.

Investigate the following and consider why we need to  
factors these when communicating.

#1

Audience

#2

Message  
Complexity

#3

Urgency

#4

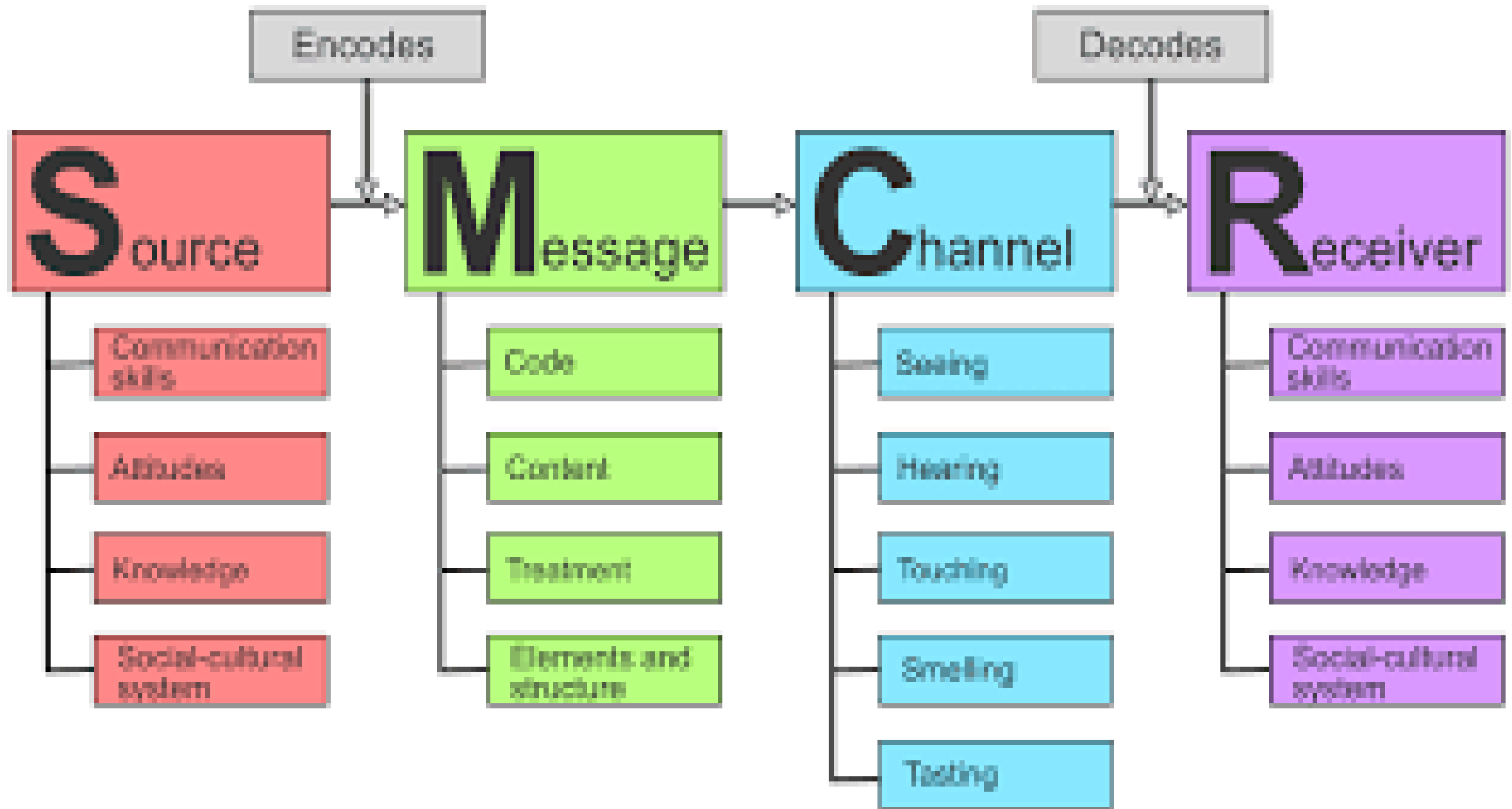
Level of Engagement  
Required

# BERLO's Communication Model

- Berlo's S-M-C-R Model focuses on the elements involved in the Communication process and looks to avoid miscommunication or errors.
- The model can be applied to marketing/advertising campaigns and workplace communication to improve strategies.
- This linear communication model emphasises the importance of the sender's and receiver's communication skills, social system, and cultural backgrounds in ensuring effective communication.

Berlo, David K. (1960). *The Process of Communication: An Introduction to Theory and Practice*





# Origin and Development

- The model has been expanded from the Shannon-Weaver communication model (detailed in previous sessions).
- The SMCR Model has since become a widely recognised framework for understanding the communication process.
- Like other linear models, the communication model is one-way with a sender and receiver, as well as message and channel.
- The SMCR Model helps individuals and organisations identify the essential elements of communication and the factors influencing their effectiveness, ultimately leading to better communication strategies, avoid miscommunications and allow for positive outcomes.

# Components of the SMCR Model

## #1 Sender (S)

The sender and their communication skills, attitude, knowledge, and socio-cultural background are crucial in encoding and transmitting the message.

## #2 Message (M)

The message is the information sent from the sender to the receiver, and its effectiveness depends on factors such as content, treatment, and code.

## #3 Channel (C)

The channel is the medium through which the message is transmitted, and its selection depends on the type of communication and the senses involved.

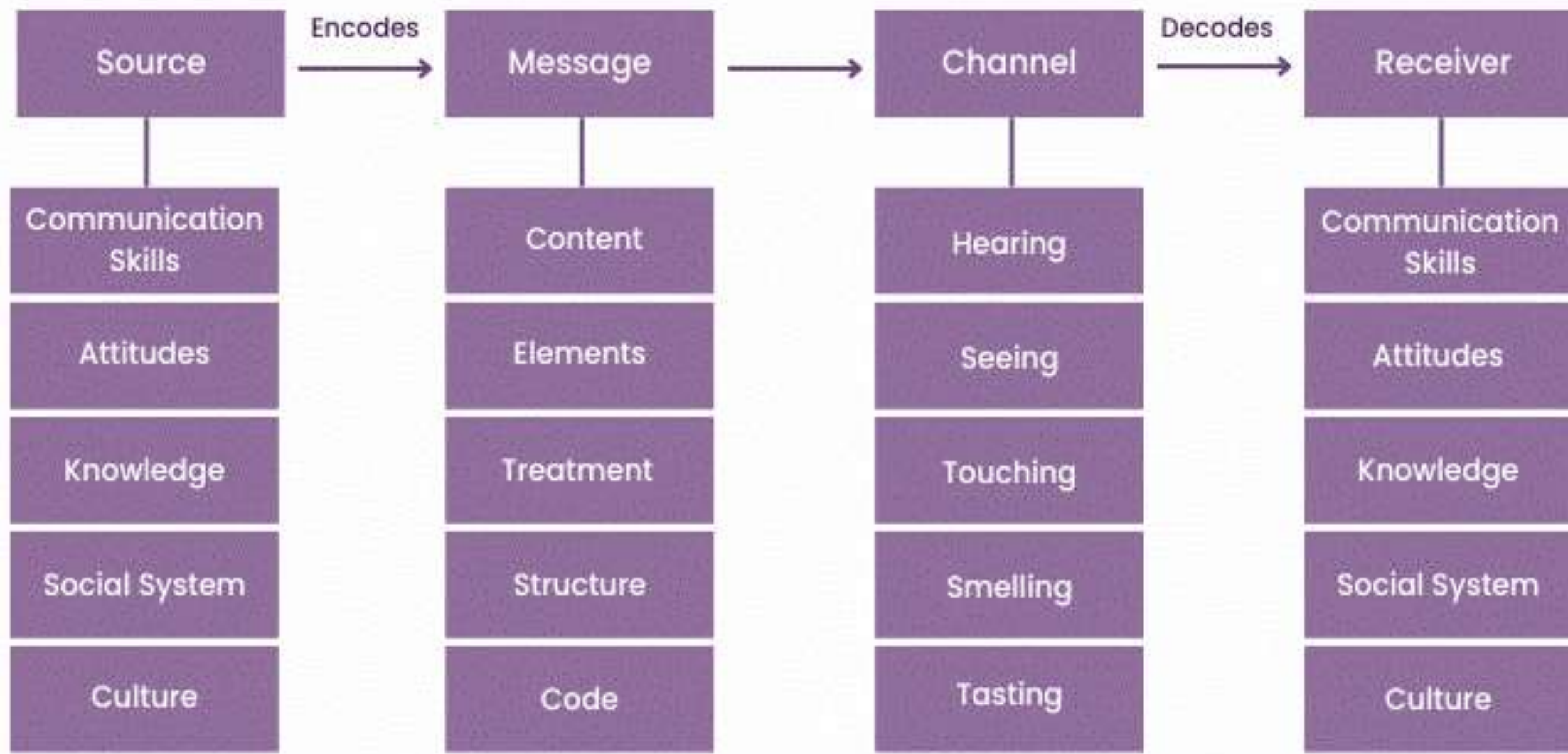
## #4 Receiver (R)

The receiver is the person who decodes and interprets the message, and their communication skills, attitude, knowledge, and socio-cultural background influence their understanding of the message.

## Read the article

Take time to develop your knowledge and understanding by reading the article >>>





# Synchronisation in Berlo's SMCR Model

- Effective communication in the SMCR Model requires synchronisation between the sender and receiver, ensuring a shared understanding and the ability to adjust the message based on feedback.
- This model ensures the message is clear, appropriate, and well-delivered and plays a crucial role in effectively delivering information to a large audience, or mass communication.



# SMCR Model in context

**#1 Source (Manager)** – Uses the right tone and credibility.

**#2 Message (Feedback)** – Is clear, constructive, and not demotivating.

**#3 Channel (Email, meeting, call)** – Chooses the best medium.

**#4 Receiver (Employee)** – Understands and accepts the feedback.

# Consider the following scenarios and apply the SMCR Model to effectively communicate the message

| Sender | Message                                  | Channel | Receiver |
|--------|------------------------------------------|---------|----------|
|        | CEO announces a new company vision       |         |          |
|        | New Product Launch                       |         |          |
|        | Crisis management (e.g., product recall) |         |          |
|        | Day-to-day team updates                  |         |          |

Identify the advantages and disadvantages of SMCR  
model

Please provide feedback to your classmates on your findings

# Advantages of Berlo's SMCR Model?

**Emphasises the Importance of Encoding & Decoding** – It highlights how a message is encoded by the sender and decoded by the receiver, making it useful in understanding communication breakdowns.

**Considers Communication Skills** – Unlike some linear models, it acknowledges that the sender's and receiver's skills (e.g., speaking, listening, and writing) affect communication effectiveness.

**Applicable in Different Contexts** – It can be applied in various fields such as business, education, media, and interpersonal communication.

**Focus on Message Clarity** – By emphasising the structure and content of the message, it encourages clear and effective communication.

**Recognises the Role of Perception & Attitude** – The model considers how attitudes, culture, and knowledge influence communication, making it more realistic than purely mechanistic models.

# Disadvantages of Berlo's SMCR Model



**Linear** – The model does not account for feedback, making it inadequate for explaining interactive or two-way communication.



**Ignores Noise and External Barriers** – Unlike models like Shannon-Weaver, it does not explicitly address potential disturbances (e.g., noise, misinterpretation) that can affect communication.



**Overemphasis on the Sender** – The model focuses heavily on the sender's role and does not fully consider how the receiver can shape or alter the communication process.



**Lacks a Social or Contextual Dimension** – It does not factor in the social, cultural, or situational context in which communication occurs, which can greatly impact meaning.



**Does Not Address Nonverbal Communication** – It primarily focuses on verbal communication and does not sufficiently consider nonverbal elements like body language, gestures, and tone.

# Lasswell Communication Model

- The Lasswell Communication Model is a foundational model of communication proposed by Harold Lasswell in 1948.
- The Model was designed to analyse mass communication and avoid miscommunication through media propaganda, particularly during the post-World War II era.

To avoid risk of miscommunication, the model breaks communication down into five key components, expressed as a set of questions:

- 1.Sender
- 2.Message
- 3.Channel
- 4.Receiver
- 5.Effect

- By breaking down the communication process into these five essential elements, Lasswell's Model allows a more comprehensive understanding of how information is transmitted between senders and receivers.



# The Five Ws



Lasswell's (1948) model has been further developed and modernised and is now referred to as the '**Five Ws**' and this model has been widely used, particularly when managing change.

Addressing the '**Five Ws**' is an essential element of all communication, getting this right is the first step in the process and is dependent upon what is required to be communicated at the time.

This is particularly important when managing change in an organisation and avoid miscommunication

# The Five Ws

## **#1 Sender (Who)**

the sender is the individual who formulates and disseminates the message.

## **#2 Message (What)**

The message component refers to the message's content.

## **#3 Channel (Which)**

The channel component relates to the medium used to convey the message.

## **#4 Receiver (Whom)**

The receiver component is the target audience, which has been analysed to identify the most effective approach to reach and influence them.

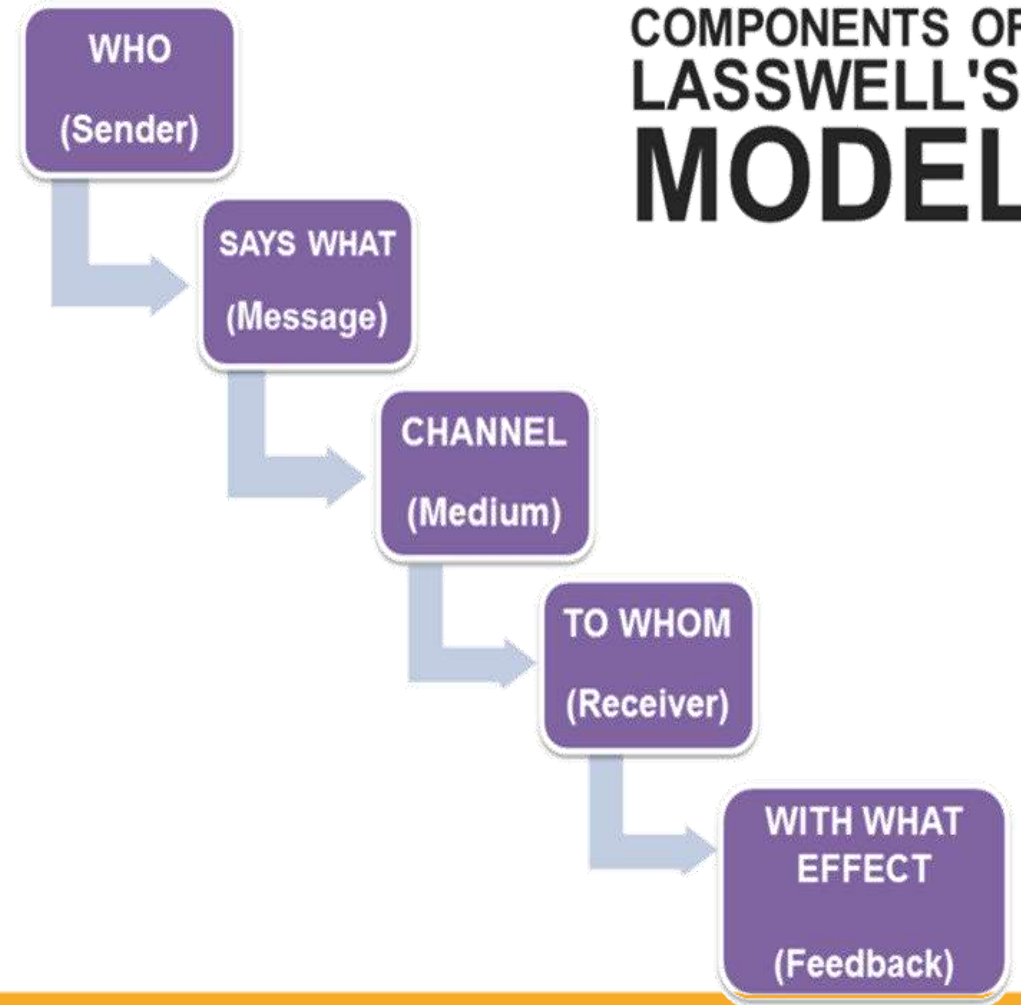
## **#5 Effect (What)**

The effect component concerns the message's impression on the recipient. By analysing the effect, communicators can understand how their message is interpreted and modify their approach to achieve the desired outcome.

Lasswell's Model has played a significant role in shaping media analysis and audience-centric strategies in both mass and interpersonal communication contexts.

# Lasswell Communication Model

- By breaking down the communication process into five components, Lasswell's Model allows researchers to discover patterns and tendencies in communication across various channels and genres.
- This has resulted in the development of systematic methodologies for analysing messages' persuasiveness, emotional appeal, and ideological foundations.
- Through its influence on content analysis, Lasswell's Model has contributed to a deeper understanding of the role of media in shaping public discourse and priorities.



# Apply The Five Ws

#1 Who? Donald Trump

#2 What?- Often uses slogans like "*Make America Great Again*" (MAGA), focuses on nationalism, economic protectionism, and attacks on opponents or the "establishment."

#3 What Channel?- active on social media (Twitter/X), campaign rallies, TV appearances, and direct speeches to his base.

#4 to Whom? Primarily appeals to US voters. His communication strategy is designed to energise his base while provoking opponents.

#5 What Effect? His communication strategy has solidified loyal followers, created a polarised political landscape, and reshaped Republican politics.





Explore the  
advantages and  
disadvantages of this  
communication  
model and report  
back

# Criticism?



- Using your judgement, critique the theory.
- Is it still relevant today? How may this theory be adapted to modern day?
- Lasswell's model is still being used today and has influenced many communication theorists. Some of them have adapted the model through additional questions like "Under What Circumstances?" and "For What Purpose?". Others used it as a starting point for the development of their own models.
- Lasswell's model is often criticised for its simplicity. A common objection is that it does not explicitly discuss a feedback loop or the influence of context on the communicative process.
- Another criticism is that it does not take the effects of noise into account. However, not everyone agrees with these objections and it has been suggested that they apply mainly to how Lasswell's model was presented and interpreted by other theorists and not to Lasswell's original formulation.

# How can we Prevent Miscommunication in Business by Using These Models?

**Remember** miscommunication occurs when there is a breakdown or distortion in the communication process, leading to misunderstandings, confusion, or even business failures.

## **Lasswell's Model:**

- Carefully analyse each stage of communication.
- Acknowledgement of 5Ws
- Consider how the audience will react to avoid backlash.

## **Berlo's Model:**

- Ensure the source understands the audience.
- Tailor the message to be clear, culturally appropriate, and relevant.
- Use the right channel—formal announcements for investors, interactive campaigns for customers.

# Another perspective- Adairs Star

John Adair's Communication Star is a simple yet effective model that highlights five key elements of effective communication. It's particularly useful for leaders and managers who need to communicate clearly and ensure understanding within their teams.

The model emphasises that communication is not just about speaking but also about ensuring understanding. Leaders who apply this model can:

- Improve team collaboration and reduce misunderstandings.
- Choose the most effective communication channels.
- Encourage active listening and constructive feedback.
- Adapt their messaging to different audiences and contexts.

# Adairs Communication Star

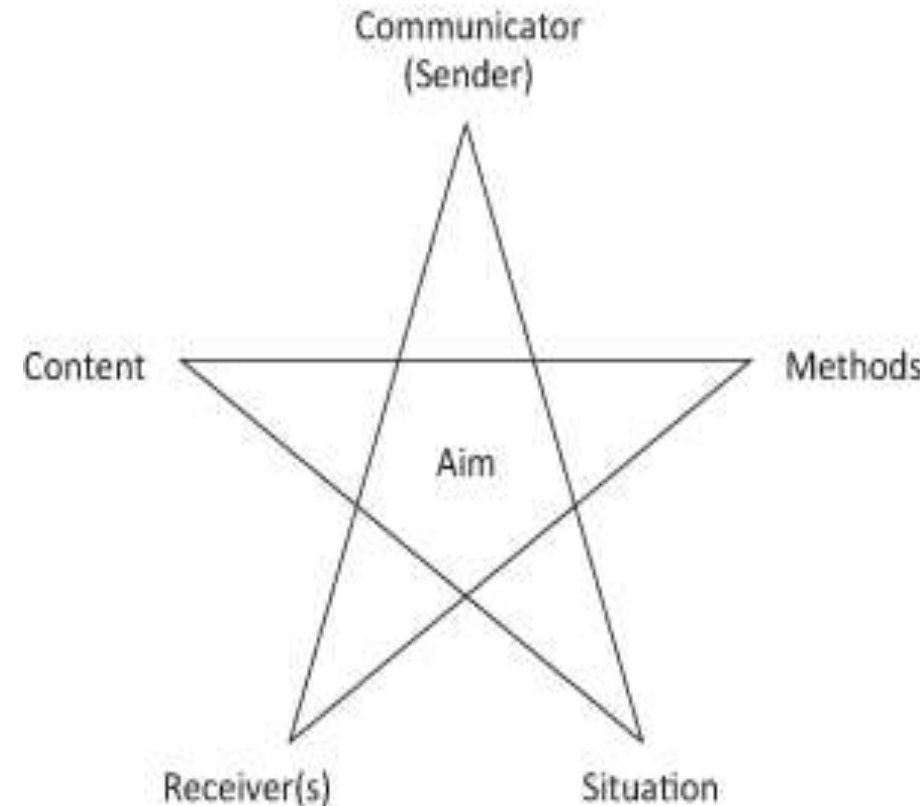
**The Sender** – The person delivering the message. They need to ensure clarity, choose the right method, and tailor the message to the audience.

**The Message** – The content being communicated. It should be clear, concise, and relevant to the receiver.

**The Receiver** – The person or group receiving the message. They need to interpret it correctly and provide feedback.

**The Medium** – The channel used to deliver the message (e.g., face-to-face, email, phone, video call). The choice of medium can affect how well the message is received.

**Feedback** – The response from the receiver that helps confirm understanding or clarify misunderstandings. Effective communication is a two-way process, so feedback is crucial.



**The Communication Star**

# Session Recap:

Have we?

- Explored both Lasswell's and Berlo's models of communication and considered how to apply these models in communication
- Considered how we can communicate effectively and avoid errors or miscommunication



# Thank you.

Coventry University

**Top 15 UK university  
5 years running**

Guardian University Guide 2016-2020

Coventry University

**Gold for outstanding  
teaching and learning**

Teaching Excellence  
Framework (TEF) 2017

Coventry University

**97% employed  
or in further study**

DLHE survey, UG UK, 2016/17  
(published 2018)

Berlo, David K. (1960). [\*The Process of Communication: An Introduction to Theory and Practice\*](#)

Chandler, Daniel; Munday, Rod (10 February 2011). "context". [\*A Dictionary of Media and Communication\*](#). OUP Oxford. [ISBN 978-0-19-956875-8](#).

Lasswell, H. (1948). "The Structure and Function of Communication in Society." In Lyman Bryson (ed.), *The Communication of Ideas*. Harper and Row

McGuire, W. (1981). "Theoretical Foundations of Campaigns." In Ronald Rice and William Paisley (eds.), *Public Communication Campaigns*, Sage.

Sapienza, Zachary S.; Iyer, Narayanan; Veenstra, Aaron S. (3 September 2015). "Reading Lasswell's Model of Communication Backward: Three Scholarly Misconceptions". *Mass Communication and Society*. **18** (5): 599–622. [doi:10.1080/15205436.2015.1063666](#). [S2CID 146389958](#).

Reddi, C. (2009). *Effective Public Relations and Media Strategy*. New Delhi: PHI Learning Private Limited. p. 42.

Watson, James; Hill, Anne (16 February 2012). ["Lasswell's model of communication"](#). *Dictionary of Media and Communication Studies*. A&C Black. [ISBN 978-1-84966-563-6](#).